jiziya was not just to tax non-Muslims, but ‘to humiliate them (the non-Muslims); and this humiliation should reach a stage where owing to the fear of the jiziya, they should not be able to wear good clothes and should never enjoy any peace of mind and be in constant dread and fear of the King’s taking away of their property’. In a claustrophobic definition of acceptable orthodox behaviour he said that ‘the harm of being in the company of a heretic exceeds that of being in the company of an Infidel: and the Shias are the worst of the heretics’. In a court where Hindus and Persians had held the very highest honours, and formed a substantial part of the mansabdari, Shaikh Sirhindi was denouncing the very fabric of society that Akbar had fashioned—it was the spirit of sulh kul that the shaikh was railing against.

After the death of Akbar, it has been said that Shaikh Sirhindi had a great influence on a penitent Jahangir, who recanted all the more tolerant policies of his father. This was untrue. Jahangir would have Shaikh Sirhindi imprisoned, and hand him over to the care of a Rajput officer in order that ‘the confusion of his [Shaikh Sirhindi’s] senses and the disorder of his brain be reduced a little’. The scaffolding of Mughal rule as laid out by Akbar would prove to be durable, used by many future Mughal rulers. To the Mughals, writes Muzaffar Alam, ‘the Sharia came to be synonymous with the namus-i ilahi (divine law) the most important task of which was to ensure a balance of conflicting interests, of harmony between groups and communities, of non-interference in their personal beliefs’.

The enduring appeal of Akbari ideals can be seen in the long life many of them had. The prohibition of cow slaughter and the killing of peacocks continued to be enforced into the early years of Shah Jahan’s reign. The jiziya remained continually abolished for about a hundred years following Akbar’s second 1579 edict, including in the first twenty years of Aurangzeb’s reign. When it was revoked, many among the Mughal elite disapproved of this, including Jahanara Begum, Shah Jahan’s daughter, and it was finally abolished again in 1712.

These measures were organically linked to the great success of Akbar’s policy of including non-Muslims in the ruling polity of the empire, and indeed the proportion of Rajput and other Hindus in the ruling class continued to increase steadily after Akbar. In the last twenty years of Aurangzeb’s reign, the Mughal elite included 31.6 per cent Rajput and other Hindus of 500 zat and above because of the recruitment of Marathas and other Hindus from the Deccan. This diverse nobility meant that even for